independence, with minimal text in the signed document and much of the other discussion either a gentleman's agreement or still undetermined (see also Walton 2008). It was therefore a voluntary agreement by the Kachin leaders to bring their land and people into a federal union between equal negotiating partners, to create something along the lines of the Shan federation or Malay federal states. After Aung San's assassination, the narrative argues, Kachin brigades in the army remained loyal to the state during the post-independence civil war while Kachin politicians worked within the system to address discriminatory economic, social, and political practices — until it became patently clear that the spirit of Panglong would never be willingly implemented. Eventually, and reluctantly, 'the Kachin' had no other recourse but to take up arms to reclaim their territory and protect their people and culture.

This narrative is well known, and will not be new to most readers. There is a great deal of truth in it, despite its mythological aspects (as Walton 2008 describes). Smith (1999) and South (2008) both agree that most of the area incorporated into the Frontier Areas on the central plains of Burma had been little affected by precolonial governments (see ICG 2013). There is consensus, *contra* to some Burman narratives of a precolonial unified kingdom, that there were frequent wars between nominally independent kingdoms prior to the colonial period (Lieberman 1978; Renard 1988; Smith 1999). The British then ruled most non-Burman areas via local leaders under the Frontier Areas Office, perpetuating separation to such an extent that at one time Burmans even needed a visa to travel to Kachin territory. It is thus not surprising that proposals involving independent statehood for the Frontier Areas were promoted prior to independence. Walton (2008) documents the Stevenson plan presented at the 1946 first Panglong conference, and a key Kachin informant pointed to a 1945 Churchill plan. Both proposals give currency to the idea that Kachin territory was not automatically being considered nor was considering itself part of Burma during the early independence negotiations. The Panglong Agreement's objective was to speed the process of independence rather than determine the details of the post-independence union (Sadan 2013), again concurring with contemporary Kachin narratives. In one sense, then, the historic and contemporary conflict has been over two competing narratives of the form of independence agreed at Panglong: a voluntary federal agreement between equals, or a commitment to union as the means to defend against subjugation now being undermined by separatism (Walton 2008).